The Move Abroad Roadmap

Your step-by-step guide to starting your life in Madrid.

Written from experience. Not from a blog post someone else wrote.

1	2	3	4	5	6
DECIDE	RESEARCH	PAPERWORK	FINANCE	LOGISTICS	ARRIVE

Proof that it is never too late to choose yourself.

How to Use This Roadmap

This is not a listicle. It is not ten things you should probably think about someday. It is a phase-by-phase plan built around the actual sequence of what needs to happen when you are moving from the US to Madrid, written by someone who did it.

Work through it in order. Each phase builds on the last. Skipping ahead is how people end up with apostilled documents and no visa appointment, or a flight booked before they have confirmed their NIE process.

Phase	Focus	When to Start
1 – Decide	Clarity and commitment	12+ months out
2 – Research	Visa, money, neighborhoods	9–12 months out
3 – Paperwork	Documents, apostilles, applications	6–9 months out
4 – Finance	Banking, budget, money transfer	4–6 months out
5 – Logistics	Housing, healthcare, what to bring	1–3 months out
6 – Arrive	First 90 days on the ground	After you land

Important:
A note on timelines: these are minimums, not targets. If you can give yourself more time, take it. The visa process alone has surprised people who thought they were organized. Start earlier than you think you need to.

Your 6-Phase Roadmap at a Glance

Six phases. One direction. Everything below expands each step in full detail.

1

12+ MONTHS BEFORE

Get Clear Before You Commit

- Take a reconnaissance trip to Madrid
- Decide on your visa category
- Consult an immigration lawyer or gestor

2

9 TO 12 MONTHS BEFORE

Research Like It Is Your Job

- Map real Madrid cost of living numbers
- Find a recommended gestor
- Understand US expat tax implications

3

6 TO 9 MONTHS BEFORE

The Paperwork Phase

- Order and apostille all documents
- Book your consulate visa appointment
- Submit your visa application

4

4 TO 6 MONTHS BEFORE

Get Your Money Right

- Open a Wise account and test transfers
- Build your 3-month relocation fund
- Brief a US expat tax specialist

5

1 TO 3 MONTHS BEFORE

The Logistics Phase

- Book short-term furnished accommodation
- Decide what to bring, ship, or sell
- Handle US accounts and subscriptions

6

AFTER YOU LAND

Land, Register, and Settle

- Register at ayuntamiento (empadronamiento)
- Book your TIE appointment
- Find your neighborhood and build routine

PHASE 1 • 12+ MONTHS BEFORE YOU MOVE

Get Clear Before You Commit

The most expensive mistake people make is starting the paperwork before they have answered the real questions. This phase is about making a grounded decision, not just an excited one.

Answer these honestly before anything else

- Why Madrid specifically? Is it the city or the idea of the city? They are different. Visit for at least two weeks in a non-summer month before committing.
- What does your income look like? Spain's Non-Lucrative Visa requires proof of passive income. The Digital Nomad Visa requires active remote employment or freelance. Neither works if your finances do not fit the criteria.
- Do you have dependents, property, or obligations that complicate a move? Identify every anchor point now. Most are manageable. None of them disappear by ignoring them.
- Are you running toward something or away from something? Madrid will not fix a life you have not examined. It will give you space to build one you actually want.

Do a reconnaissance trip

- Stay at least 10 to 14 days. Rent an apartment, not a hotel room.
- Live like a resident: buy groceries, take the metro, sit in the neighborhood you think you want to live in on a Tuesday morning.
- Visit in October, November, March, or April. Madrid in July is not Madrid the rest of the year.
- Pay attention to whether you feel at ease or just on vacation. Those are different feelings.

> ***Madrid neighborhoods at a glance:***
> *Neighborhoods worth exploring on your trip: Malasaña (creative, loud), Chueca (vibrant, expat-friendly), Salamanca (polished, expensive), Lavarápies (multicultural, artsy), Chambertí (residential, calm). Each one is a different city.*

Decide on your visa category

- **Non-Lucrative Visa (NLV):** For passive income, pensions, savings. You cannot work in Spain on this visa. Requires approximately €27,800/year income (verify annually).
- **Digital Nomad Visa:** For remote workers or freelancers working primarily for non-Spanish clients. Requires €2,849/month (2026). Allows you to work remotely legally.
- **Entrepreneur Visa:** For starting a business in Spain. Requires a business plan and government approval. More complex.
- **Student Visa:** For enrolling in an accredited program. Used as an entry point by some but is not a direct path to residency.

If you are unsure which visa fits your situation, consult a Spanish immigration lawyer before starting any paperwork. A one-hour consultation costs far less than filing the wrong application.

PHASE 2 • 9–12 MONTHS BEFORE YOU MOVE

Research Like It Is Your Job

By this point you have chosen your visa category and done a reconnaissance trip. Now you build the knowledge base you will need to make every decision that follows.

Understand the real cost of living in Madrid

Expense	Estimated Monthly Range (EUR)	Notes
Rent (1-bed, central)	€1,200 – €1,600	Salamanca/Chueca higher
Rent (1-bed, outer)	€900 – €1,200	Carabanchel, Vallecas
Groceries	€200 – €300	Mercadona is your friend
Dining out	€150 – €400	Menú del día €12–15
Transport (metro abono)	€54.60	Monthly Zone A pass
Private health insurance	€50 – €200	Required for NLV
Utilities	€120 – €150	Spikes in summer
Internet + mobile	€45 – €65	Bundled fiber + SIM
TOTAL (excl. rent)	**€820 – €1,280**	**Per person, per month**

Find a gestor

A gestor is a Spanish administrative professional who handles paperwork on your behalf. For visa applications, residency renewals, and tax filings, a good gestor is not optional. Look for one who works specifically with expats and English-speaking clients. Expect to pay €200 to €600 for visa application assistance. Ask in expat Facebook groups for personal recommendations.

Build your Spain knowledge base

- Learn how the NIE (Número de Identificación de Extranjero) works. You will need it for almost everything.
- Understand empadronamiento: registering at the local town hall. Required for visa renewals and many services.
- Research the Spanish tax treaty with the US. You still file US taxes. Spain taxes you as a resident after 183 days. Speak to a US expat tax specialist now, not at tax time.

PHASE 3 • 6–9 MONTHS BEFORE YOU MOVE

The Paperwork Phase

This phase is unglamorous, time-sensitive, and the one most people underestimate. Build your document package methodically. One missing item can delay your visa by months.

Core documents required for most Spain visas

Document	What You Need	Watch Out For
Valid US Passport	Valid 1+ year beyond stay	Renew if under 18 months
FBI Background Check	Federal level. Apostilled.	Takes 3–6 weeks. Order early.
Proof of Income	Last 3–6 months. Notarized.	Statements must match contracts
Private Health Insurance	Spain-approved. No copays.	Sanitas, Adeslas, Asisa accepted
Proof of Accommodation	Rental contract or host letter	Must be signed and dated
Passport Photos	EU format: 35mm x 45mm	Not US standard size
Criminal Record	Apostilled. Translated.	Under 6 months old at filing
Visa Application Form	Completed in Spanish	Your gestor handles this

Understanding apostilles

- Contact your Secretary of State for state-issued documents.
- The US Department of State handles federal documents like FBI checks.
- Allow 4 to 8 weeks. Expedited options exist but cost more.
- Once apostilled, documents need certified Spanish translation. Your gestor can recommend a sworn translator.

Critical scheduling note:
Apply for your visa appointment at the Spanish Consulate covering your US state. Wait times vary from 2 weeks to 3 months by location. Check availability before finalizing your move date. The appointment date anchors everything else.

PHASE 4 • 4–6 MONTHS BEFORE YOU MOVE

Get Your Money Right

Financial setup is the phase people leave the latest and regret the most. Sort this before you sort anything else in logistics.

Build your relocation fund

- Target a minimum of 3 months of full living expenses in liquid savings before you leave, separate from ongoing income.
- Budget €5,000 to €8,000 for one-time arrival costs: first month rent, security deposit (1 to 2 months), furniture if unfurnished, initial paperwork fees.
- Keep a US emergency fund intact. You need a financial cushion in both places for the first year.

Set up international money transfer

- **Wise:** Best exchange rates for regular transfers. Open now and test a small transfer before you need it.
- **Revolut:** Good for day-to-day spending. Pair with Wise for larger transfers.
- Avoid airport and hotel currency exchange. The rates are punitive.

Opening a Spanish bank account

- **Before arrival:** Open a Wise or N26 account. Both are EU-based, do not require a NIE, and give you a Euro IBAN immediately.
- **After arrival:** Open an account at Santander, BBVA, or CaixaBank. Santander has English-speaking staff at many Madrid branches.
- Ask specifically for a *cuenta de no residente* if your residency is not yet confirmed.

Understand your tax situation now, not later

- US citizens must file US federal taxes regardless of where they live. The Foreign Earned Income Exclusion may apply.
- Spain taxes you as a resident after 183 days. Once a tax resident you are subject to Spanish income tax on worldwide income.
- FBAR filing is required if you hold more than $10,000 in foreign accounts at any point during the year.

PHASE 5 • 1–3 MONTHS BEFORE YOU MOVE

The Logistics Phase

By now your visa is in process or approved. This phase is about the practical execution of actually leaving and being ready when you land.

Finding housing in Madrid before you arrive

- Do not sign a long-term lease before spending time in the neighborhood. Book a furnished short-term rental for your first 4 to 8 weeks.
- Use the first weeks to apartment-hunt in person. The best rentals are found on Idealista and Fotocasa.
- Landlords typically ask for NIE, proof of income, and sometimes a Spanish guarantor or extra deposit. Budget 1 to 2 months deposit.
- Furnished apartments cost more but save you thousands in setup. For a first apartment, furnished is almost always right.

What to bring, ship, or let go

- **Bring:** All documents in carry-on, laptop, medications with prescriptions, sentimental items that cannot be replaced.
- **Ship only if it makes financial sense:** International shipping is expensive. Price it honestly. Most furniture is not worth shipping.
- **Sell or store:** Large furniture, cars, US-specific appliances. Spain uses 220V/50Hz. US appliances run on 110V/60Hz.

Before you leave the US

- Notify US bank and credit cards of your move.
- Set up mail forwarding (US Global Mail, Traveling Mailbox).
- Bring 3 to 6 months of prescription medications. Confirm each is legal to bring into Spain.
- Carry all visa documents and critical paperwork in your carry-on. Never in checked luggage.

PHASE 6 • YOUR FIRST 90 DAYS IN MADRID

Land, Register, and Settle

You are here. This phase is about getting the administrative foundation in place so that everything else, the life part, can actually begin.

Week 1 to 2: Immediate priorities

- Get a local SIM card immediately. Movistar, Vodafone, and Orange all have English support. A local number is required for almost every form you will fill out.
- Open a Spanish bank account if you have not already.
- Register at the ayuntamiento for your empadronamiento. You need a rental contract or landlord letter.
- Book your TIE appointment (Tarjeta de Identidad de Extranjero) as soon as possible. Appointments can be weeks out.

Month 1: Getting set up properly

- Confirm your NIE is active and your TIE appointment is scheduled.
- Register with a local doctor if you have access to the public health system. If not, identify your private clinic and GP.
- Get a transport abono. The Zone A monthly metro card covers all of central Madrid for €54.60/month.

The stuff nobody warns you about

- Bureaucracy moves slowly. Bring snacks, a book, and patience to every appointment.
- Everything closes between roughly 2pm and 5pm. Plan errands accordingly.
- Dinner is at 9pm or later. If you eat at 6pm you will be dining alone.
- The first 60 days can feel bureaucratic, lonely, and overwhelming simultaneously. This is normal. It passes. Build in one enjoyable thing every single day regardless of what else is happening.

Community:
Finding your people: Madrid's expat community is active. Facebook groups (Americans in Madrid, Madrid Expats, Women in Madrid) are genuinely helpful. Language exchange events (intercambios) are one of the best ways to meet locals. Give it 90 days before you decide whether you have found your footing.

Master Checklist

Print this page. Check things off as you complete them.

Phase 1: Decide (12+ months out)

- ■ Take a reconnaissance trip to Madrid (minimum 10 days)
- ■ Confirm visa category based on your income situation
- ■ Consult an immigration lawyer or gestor for your case
- ■ Assess all US obligations: property, dependents, accounts

Phase 2: Research (9–12 months out)

- ■ Research Madrid neighborhoods and shortlist 2 to 3
- ■ Find a recommended gestor who works with expats
- ■ Research US expat tax implications and find a specialist
- ■ Join 2 to 3 Madrid expat online communities

Phase 3: Paperwork (6–9 months out)

- ■ Order FBI background check
- ■ Request and apostille all required documents
- ■ Renew passport if needed
- ■ Purchase Spain-approved private health insurance
- ■ Book Spanish Consulate visa appointment
- ■ Submit visa application with gestor support

Phase 4: Finance (4–6 months out)

- ■ Open Wise account and test an international transfer
- ■ Build 3-month liquid relocation fund
- ■ Estimate one-time arrival costs and budget for them
- ■ Brief US expat tax specialist on your situation
- ■ Set up mail forwarding service

Phase 5: Logistics (1–3 months out)

- ■ Book short-term furnished accommodation for first 4–8 weeks
- ■ Decide what to bring, ship, sell, or store
- ■ Bring 3 to 6 months of prescription medications
- ■ Notify US bank and credit cards of move

- Pack all documents in carry-on bag

Phase 6: First 90 Days

- Buy local SIM card on arrival
- Register at ayuntamiento for empadronamiento
- Open Spanish bank account
- Book TIE appointment
- Register with local doctor or identify private clinic
- Get monthly metro abono
- Build in one enjoyable thing every day for the first 60 days

---

shelefthechat.com • Stories of bold choices and building a life on your own terms in Madrid. This guide is for informational purposes only. Visa requirements and regulations change. Always verify with a licensed immigration professional and official Spanish government sources.